

Classroom Calming Strategies Routine Chart

This chart provides teachers with practical ways to implement calming strategies in a high school classroom. It includes examples for whole group, small group, and individual student use.

Strategy	Whole-Group Use	Small-Group Use	Individual Student Use
Grounding Techniques (5-4-3-2-1)	Begin class or after a stressful activity by guiding all students through 5 things you see, 4 things you touch, 3 things you hear, 2 things you smell, 1 thing you taste. Model out loud.	During group work or projects, prompt groups to pause and do a quick grounding check together if stress arises.	Quietly guide a student who is overwhelmed through the grounding steps at their desk or in a calm corner.
Mindful Breathing (Box Breathing)	Lead a 1-minute box breathing exercise at the start or midpoint of class. Use inhale 4, hold 4, exhale 4, hold 4 pattern.	During group activities, prompt students to try box breathing together if the group seems tense or distracted.	Invite the student to step aside or do box breathing at their desk to manage anxiety or frustration.
Movement Breaks	Schedule 1–2-minute stretches or shaking breaks between lessons. Introduce classroom yoga poses.	During small-group work, encourage quick movement resets when focus wanes.	Allow students to stretch at their desk or in a designated space when feeling restless or anxious.
Journaling or Drawing	Begin or end class with 3–5 minutes for reflective writing or doodling. Provide optional prompts.	During small-group discussions, have students reflect or sketch their thoughts before sharing.	Offer journaling or drawing as a calming activity for students in crisis; provide prompts like “What can I control right now?”
Positive Self-Talk Prompts	Lead affirmations at the start or after challenging activities, e.g., “I am capable. I can handle challenges.”	Encourage group members to share positive phrases or mantras with each other before a task.	Suggest personal mantras for individual students to repeat during moments of stress.

Implementation Tips:

- Normalize all strategies; emphasize that everyone can use them.
- Model each strategy consistently.
- Use visual or auditory cues (timers, chimes) for transitions.
- Provide choice so students can select the strategy that works best for them.

Suggested Routine Example: - **Start of Class:** 1 min box breathing, 5-4-3-2-1 grounding, positive affirmation. - **Mid-Class Transition:** 1–2-minute movement break. - **End of Class:** Journaling or drawing reflection + closing positive self-talk.

This chart can be printed as a **one-page teacher guide** and shared with students as needed.